

Impact: High Difficulty: Hard Misuse risk: The main failure mode is validating the inaccurate claim instead of the understandable experience, or

CORE FORMULA

Name what makes sense -> avoid endorsing the claim -> state your boundary or view separately -> invite the next step. -> Short form: notice -> name or respond -> invite -> calibrate -> release. -> "I can see why that landed that way" — even though I read the decision differently. -> "That is a reasonable concern to raise. The frustration makes sense; I don't see it the same way." -> "I can see why it felt dismissive. I don't think that was the intent, but the impact is worth talking through."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Say "I can see why that landed that way," or "That makes sense as a concern, even if I see the decision differently."

BEST FOR

- Disagreement
- Complaints
- Defensiveness
- Boundary conversations
- Moments where someone has a real concern but a shaky conclusion

PHRASE BANK

Quick acknowledgements · Concise / one-line

- "I can see why."
- "That makes sense as a concern."
- "I get the frustration, even if I disagree."
- "That's fair to raise."
- "I can see why that landed that way."
- "Yeah, that would land badly."
- "I hear the frustration."

Warm validation · Social / supportive

- "I can see why that felt unfair."
- "That would be frustrating from your side."
- "I understand why you read it that way, even though I see the situation differently."
- "It makes sense that it hit you like that."
- "I can see this really matters to you."
- "Anyone would feel let down by that."
- "That sounds like it stung, and I get why."

Work & meetings · Professional / decisions

- "That is a reasonable concern to raise."
- "I can see why the process felt unclear."
- "The frustration makes sense; I don't read the decision the same way."
- "That's a fair point about the timeline; the call still stands, for these reasons."
- "I understand the impact on your team. Let me walk you through where it went."
- "You're right that it moved fast. I don't agree that it skipped your input."
- "The concern is legitimate. My read of the trade-off is different."

Name it, then state your view · Separating validation from agreement

- "I can see why that felt dismissive. I don't think that was the intent."
- "The concern makes sense. My decision is still the same, and here's why."
- "I understand why it looked that way. I read what happened differently."
- "That's a fair thing to be annoyed about. I still need to hold the line here."
- "I get why you'd want that. My answer is no, and it's not about you."
- "Two things are true: your frustration makes sense, and I don't agree with the conclusion."
- "I hear you, and I'm not going to change the decision — let me explain it, though."

De-escalation & repair · Softening / recovery

- "I don't mean I agree with every part; I mean I understand why it felt that way."
- "Let me separate two things: the concern makes sense, and my decision is still the same."
- "I phrased that badly. I want to acknowledge the impact without pretending the facts are different."
- "I can see this matters, and I still need to hold the boundary."
- "That came out more dismissive than I meant. The frustration is fair."
- "Can we slow down? I don't want to argue the point before you feel heard."
- "I jumped to defending myself. Let me start with the part that makes sense."

Under pressure · Heated / guarded moments

- "I'm not going to pretend I agree, but I do understand why you're angry."
- "Your frustration is real. I still can't sign off on this, and I'll tell you why."
- "I can see how much this matters. That doesn't move the limit, but it does change how we talk about it."
- "I'm hearing that you feel ignored. I don't accept that I ignored you — let's look at it together."
- "This clearly landed hard. I want to understand it before I defend anything."
- "I get that you're upset with me. I'd still make the same call, and I won't dress that up."

Digital / text · Messages & email

- "I can see why that landed badly."
- "That concern makes sense. I do see the facts a bit differently."
- "Fair to ask about that. Here's where I'm coming from."
- "Totally get the frustration — my read on the decision is a bit different, though."
- "Makes sense you'd flag it. Short version: I don't think it was ignored, and here's why."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "You're right." — may falsely agree and store up conflict for later.
Better: "I understand why you're upset, but?" — validates, then the "but" quietly erases it.
Best: "I can see why that felt dismissive. I don't think that was the intent, but the impact is worth talking through." — validates the impact while keeping the distinction.
2. Weak: "Fine, we'll do it your way." — caves to keep the peace.
Better: "I hear you, but the answer's no." — holds the line but skips the understanding.
Best: "I can see why you'd want this, and it's reasonable to ask. My answer is still no — here's the reason." — understanding and boundary, kept apart.
3. Weak: "That's just how it is." — dismisses the concern outright.
Better: "I get it, these things happen." — vague, and sounds like a brush-off.
Best: "That's a reasonable thing to raise, and I can see the impact on you. Let me walk you through the decision." — names the concern, then explains without denying it.

DECISION TREE

If Can you identify the understandable part?

Name that part only — the feeling, context or concern, not the conclusion.

"I can see why that felt unfair."

If Would your words imply agreement with a false claim?

Change the sentence so you validate the experience, not the inaccuracy.

"I understand why it looked that way — I read what happened differently."

If Do you need to hold a boundary or a different view?

State it separately, after the validation, without a cancelling "but".

"The concern makes sense. My decision is still the same, and here's why."

If Are they escalating?

Slow down and reflect before you explain anything.

"This clearly landed hard. Let me make sure I've got it before I respond."

If Have they corrected, answered or moved on?

Release the technique and follow the person — don't keep validating.

"Okay — where do you want to take it from here?"

SCENARIOS

A complaint

Validate the impact before you explain the decision. — "I can see why that felt unfair. Let me show you how the call was made."

Setting a boundary

Acknowledge the disappointment while holding the limit. — "I get why you'd want this. The answer's still no, and it's not personal."

Team conflict

Validate the process concern without accepting inaccurate blame. — "The concern about how it was handled is fair. I don't agree that it was ignored."

Personal disagreement

Name what makes sense before you give your view. — "I can see why you read it that way. Here's how it looked from where I stood."

Someone getting defensive

Reflect the feeling first, so they don't have to defend it. — "You're allowed to be annoyed about this. I'm not here to talk you out of it."

A written or text complaint

Lead with the acknowledgement, then your view in one clean line. — "Totally fair to flag it. My read on the decision is a bit different — here's why."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Validation would imply agreement with unsafe behaviour
- You cannot yet identify what is genuinely understandable
- The person needs a clear limit first, not acknowledgement
- You are using validation as a manipulative softener
- Physical safety or an emergency response takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the moment

List three moments from the past week where you disagreed but the other person still had a real point. Note what was understandable in each.

Day 2 — Separate the two parts

For each moment, write the understandable experience on one line and the claim you didn't agree with on another. Keep them apart on the page.

Day 3 — Build the ladder

Take one real line you've used before. Write it as weak, better and best — validating the impact without erasing it with a "but".

Day 4 — Shorten it

Say your best line aloud twice, then cut it by about a third until it sounds like ordinary speech, not a script.

Day 5 — Kill the "but"

Rewrite three of your validations so the boundary or view stands in its own sentence, with no cancelling "but" or "however".

Day 6 — Field test

Use the minimum viable move once in a low-stakes disagreement. Afterwards, note whether they expanded, corrected, softened, shortened or redirected.

Day 7 — Practise recovery

In a slightly harder conversation, use one validation and, if it lands wrong, one recovery line. Review which recovery line felt most natural.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name what was genuinely understandable, rather than just soothe them?
- Did I keep my view or boundary in its own sentence, without a cancelling "but"?
- Did I use plain language, not a script or therapy-speak?
- Did I keep the other person's autonomy intact?
- Did I stop after one move instead of over-validating?
- Did the exchange get easier, or more self-conscious?